said: ‘Kiran, I don’t think the present top brass in Delhi Police would want you to be a part of the police set-up. Why not work from here? Consider it and we begin right away.’ I said: ‘Sir, in that case, could it be a temporary arrangement, I may return after we set up the redressal and response systems.’ He said: ‘Yes.’ I thanked him and left.

The LG had created two posts in his office for special secretaries to function as advisors. It was for the first time that both the prestigious posts had gone to police officers. There was great surprise, and even anguish, in certain circles that Kiran was going to work with one of the finest civil servants India had produced. Being at the LG’s office, for many, was a very significant and prestigious appointment – for Kiran it meant finally getting back to work, but this time with a ‘missionary’.

The news of Kiran’s prospective appointment was reported by the media. It was soon confirmed by the LG himself through various interactions that he used to have with the public. He was always for voluntary observance of laws with emphasis on a participative-transparent-accountable administration. He was a people-friendly, sensitive and ethical civil servant. He hoped to mould his administration in the same way. The LG’s public confidence soared and so did the people’s expectations. Complainants seeking redressal of their grievances started flocking to the LG’s office, which hitherto was not accessible to the general public in large numbers and certainly not to people coming without a prior appointment. The complaints received were forwarded to the concerned departments for action as deemed fit. Only in a very few instances were reports called for.

In the LG’s office (and its offshoots), there was only one personal computer, which was lying almost idle; this was certainly not the ideal state of affairs. Khanna declared that his office would not be a ‘post office’, but one that would resolve problems with the best of the available technology. This declaration set the mission statement and put in place the work methodology in the LG’s office.

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On all days, throughout the working period and even later, Kiran’s office was deluged with complaints. They ranged from garbage not being cleared for long periods to existing and ongoing unauthorized constructions being made in collusion with enforcement agencies; from public parks being illegally occupied to non-attendance of staff; and from callous misbehaviour by officials to files missing for years on end. The complaints also related to various matters coming under the purview of the Delhi Police.

The office became a huge mirror reflecting all that was going wrong with the management of the city. While those who met the LG personally did so by appointment, that too in large numbers daily, and in once-a-week public hearings, anybody could just walk in to meet Kiran Bedi and not leave till she heard him or her out. Since Kiran’s post was new, it had no back-up infrastructure to deliver the goods. There were numerous matters of detail, which were critical to match the performance with the expectations generated. With the prior concurrence of the LG, Kiran drew upon some personal staff who had worked with her earlier when she was with the Delhi Police and who, she knew, would understand the LG’s mission statement without any loss of time. She put together a team of serving and retired officers assisted by a band of young computer operators, who were students. She created adequate office space and brought in all the infrastructure necessary, such as computers, telephone lines, fax machines and photocopiers, to meet the growing demands of the increasing number of visitors and complaints. She called on Dr N. Sheshagiri, then chairman of the National Informatics Centre (NIC), New Delhi, and sought his help for the computerization of the redressal system in the LG’s office. Kiran and her team of officers along with the NIC computer staff designed programmes